

Grown-up's Playbook: The Great Wooden Horse

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Great Wooden Horse: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale with no battle in it at all: the two old camps are simply weary of quarrelling, and the heroes win by ending the quarrel with a kind surprise.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the beach.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (a clever plan), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for Penelope's thread, a few small treats or tokens for the basket of honey and figs, and any shell or cup for the conch horn. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On these shores, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Clever gives you one free hint.
2	You catch your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The wary city at the gates is the "obstacle", but there is no villain here at all, and not one soldier hides inside the horse. The proud city is simply tired of an old quarrel, just as the seafarers are. The tale is won not by beating anyone but by surprising the weary city with friendship: a warm note on the conch horn, an open door, and a shared basket of figs. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Great Wooden Horse: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Building the Horse (Normal)

The challenge. The great wooden horse must be built tall, strong, and steady on its wheels, with a little door in its side. The players help the carpenters work out how the wooden pieces fit and balance, and how many planks the build will need.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Cleverness, Logic, and a little Spatial thinking and Maths. The clever move is to use **Penelope's thread** to measure a piece before it is cut, and to count the planks together so each leg matches and the body balances. Sorting the pieces by shape, or laying out a simple plan before building, works just as well. Settling on any sensible, balanced plan passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a friendly carpenter hold up two planks and ask, "Which of these is longer, do you think?", or let them spend an energy star to "measure twice and cut once". Counting out loud together always gets there. Any steady plan raises the horse and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: Filling It with Friendship (Easy)

The challenge. The horse is built and its door stands open. The players choose what to put inside. The whole idea is a kind surprise, so the answer is never soldiers and never anything frightening, only friendly things.

Intended solution. This is a gentle Social-emotional and Logic moment. Any warm, welcoming choice works: the **basket of honey and figs** to share, garlands of bright **flowers**, and a **little drum** for happy music. Ask the children which gifts say "let us be friends", and let them explain why. Naming any kind gift, and saying why it is kind, passes the stop.

Fallback. If a child suggests something fierce, gently wonder aloud together, "How would the city folk feel if they opened the door and found that? What would make them smile instead?" Steer warmly towards the figs, the flowers, and the drum. Choosing any kind thing is a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Surprise at the Gates (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes roll the horse up to the city gates, which stay shut. The watchful folk on the walls look wary and weary. The players may feel this is a standoff. It is not. It is a gift waiting to be opened.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Courage and Social-emotional warmth. The city is not an enemy, only tired and unsure. Any genuine, friendly gesture works: sounding the **conch horn** as a warm hello, opening the horse's door, sharing the **figs**, calling up a kind word, or beating the little drum. When the surprise of friendship lands, the great gates swing open. Showing the city any clear sign of friendship passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or imagine the gates will never open, have a single curious child appear at the top of the wall and call down, "Is that... for us?" The smallest kindness, a wave, a fig held up, a soft note on the horn, melts the wariness and the gates begin to open.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a soldier in the horse. When the surprise of friendship works, the proud city opens its gates, the two camps spread a feast together on the hillside, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles from the calm water. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and loyal to a friend.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 1.5, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.